Betula nigra 'Little King'
Fox Valley® Dwarf River Birch

Family: Betulaceae



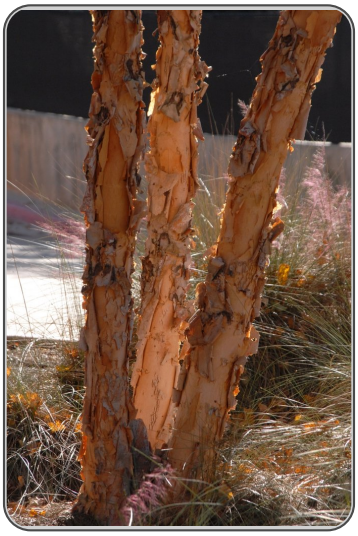
HABIT



OTHER



LEAF



BARK

QUICK FACTS

Plant Type: Small tree or large shrub

Evergreen or deciduous
Deciduous

Growth & Size
Rate: Not stated
Size: 8–12 ft (2.4–3.5 m) high × 9–12 ft (2.7–3.5 m) wide in 10 years; up to 15–20 ft (4.5–6 m) at maturity in ideal conditions. Dense, compact, multi-stemmed with irregular crown

Sun

Water

Soil
Medium to wet soils preferred; adaptable to clay. Tolerates wet soil, urban conditions, and a range of soils

Zone 8a
Hardy in USDA Zones 4–9. Suitable for Atlanta Zone 8a. Compact river birch with excellent heat tolerance. Ornamental exfoliating bark appears early. Resistant to bronze birch borer and leaf spot. Good for smaller gardens or wet sites

ORIGIN AND CHARACTERISTICS

Origin
Cultivar of Betula nigra (river birch). Selected by Jim King of King Nursery, Oswego, Illinois, for uniform compact habit, soil adaptability, disease/pest resistance (including bronze birch borer), and early ornamental bark.
Sold as FOX VALLEY®. Chicagoland Grows® introduction

Form
Deciduous multi-stemmed shrub/small tree. Leathery diamond-shaped leaves (1.5–3.5 in) turn yellow in fall. Salmon-pink to reddish-brown bark exfoliates at an early age to reveal lighter inner bark (cinnamon-red and pale salmon patterns). Dense compact habit. Insignificant catkins. Dwarf river birch prized for early exfoliating bark and compact size. Superior disease resistance compared to many birches. Heat tolerant. Ideal where space is limited. Trade name FOX VALLEY®

Foliage
Not stated

Flowers and fruit
Not stated

Bark
Not stated

PLANTING NOTES

Establishment

Plant in full sun to part shade with moist to wet, well-drained soil. Excellent for smaller landscapes, rain gardens, or wet areas. Compact form works as accent or in groups for screening. Minimal care once established. Bark is the primary ornamental feature

HEALTH

Health

Extremely resistant to bronze birch borer. Good resistance to leaf spot diseases. Heat tolerant. Low maintenance. Generally pest- and disease-resistant when properly sited

Symptoms

None stated